

Catechesis: The cross, with Bishop Emilianos. 2026-03-15

VIDEO: <https://youtu.be/a-bShM-6448>

Partially edited, close to verbatim transcript

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00:00

Fr. Seraphim:

In the name of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit. Amen. This is Bishop Emilianos. He's been going to school in the Dallas area, so he's going to be here for at least two years.

So I'm very pleased to have met him and gotten his blessing, and he's already taught twice and preached twice. So this will be the third catechesis.

Your Grace, I thought we'd talk about the Cross, especially before the Sunday of the Cross, of course, and then anything about the Cross.

The Cross is probably the most misunderstood thing among Protestants. For them, all salvation is basically what happened on the Cross.

And so sometimes there's a real disconnect when people are talking about the Cross.

I actually had a person leave the Church because he thought that our teaching about the Cross was heresy.

Audience:Wow.

Fr. Seraphim:Because he liked his teaching about the Cross, which was your standard kind of Protestant.

So I don't know if you know standard Protestant teaching. You might not know it.

Bishop Emilianos:

No.

Fr. Seraphim:So if you could summarize it for—

Okay.

He's had the fortune to not grow up in the sort of cesspool of theology that we have in the West.

And so the standard kind of teaching about the Cross is the so-called substitutionary atonement.

And what are the three initials?

Audience:PSA.

Fr. Seraphim:PSA — penal substitutionary atonement.

The idea is that Jesus Christ, the only-begotten Son of God, becomes man in order to take on all the punishment of mankind, all the sin, because God the Father is just and justice requires punishment for sin.

Bishop Emilianos:

So there's no love in it.

Fr. Seraphim:There's not really love.

And it's a very strange thing because twice, of course, in the Scriptures St. Paul talks about we are reconciled to God from the Cross, right?

We are reconciled to God on the Cross.

But their teaching would be that God gets reconciled to us because of what Christ did on the Cross.

In other words, in my mind — my simple mind — God the Father changed His mind, which would make Him not God.

Bishop Emilianos:

Yes.

Fr. Seraphim:See, so their idea is that there's a penalty for sin and Christ paid the penalty because of love.

You know: "Greater love has no man than this, that he lay down his life for his friends."

And He took on all the punishment because He's an infinite being.

He took on all of the sins infinitely, and then all of our sins — past, present, future — are forgiven.

Of course, if we live with belief. It's not just automatic for all of mankind.

And that's their basic teaching.

It's a juridical idea.

It's a contract.

It's like I ask Jesus into my heart. Jesus then says your sins are forgiven because of what I did.

And now many would say — not everyone — but some would say, okay, once you've said that then you'll be saved no matter what.

You know, so-called eternal security.

Audience:Yes.

Fr. Seraphim:Okay.

And of course we don't have any of those ideas.

Bishop Emilianos:

Yes. Of course.

Fr. Seraphim:So maybe, Vladika, maybe you can start with that.

I think put it the other direction because the—

Oh no, that's the—

Oh, that's the transmitter.

Oh.

Oh, the receiver. Excuse me.

Okay.

So Vladika, why don't you tell us what our theology of the Cross is in five or ten minutes?

Bishop Emilianos:

I can tell you what I can tell you, Father, but I'm not really sure that it's what you're expecting me to say.

I usually don't say things that people expect me to say.

Fr. Seraphim:Okay. It's good to be mysterious a little.

Bishop Emilianos:

So some Fathers of the Church — and this is called *theologoumena* — which means that it's not exactly theology; it's like talk about theology.

So some Fathers of the Church say that even if Adam and Eve did not fall, God's love was so great for humankind that Christ would have sacrificed Himself again.

And it's interesting because we need to understand that the whole mystery of the Incarnation and of the Cross — the Cross was the end of the human life of Christ.

This whole history happened because God is love.

So behind the Cross there is this love.

And this is what I tried to talk about today.

I'm not sure how it came across — if it was understood or not.

But Christ — God loves us so much that for Him it would have been considered unconceivable not to sacrifice Himself for us.

So the Cross for Christ is an indication of His love.

And if we don't understand it as such, it's interesting because then what usually happens is that we sacrifice others for ourselves instead of us being sacrificed for God and for others.

And this is what we call self-centeredness.

Or what we call narcissism.

Or whatever we call it.

But this is basically what happens when we don't understand that the Cross is a symbol of love.

And this is the main thing that I wanted to say.

Fr. Seraphim: The same — that the Cross is absolutely a symbol of love.

I always thought of the Cross that, of course, the Cross was prophesied. It was clear that He was going to die on the Cross because it was prophesied.

I mean Moses — with the wood and making the waters sweet, and the axe head floating when they threw the wood in the water, etc., etc.

And also an even more explicit thing: Psalm 21, which is the description of a man on the Cross.

So no doubt He was going to die on the Cross.

And it was His vehicle so that He could go down to Hades and destroy sin and death.

And it's a wonderful symbol.

Imagine if He was stoned to death. What are you going to do — just wear a rock on your chest?

I mean it's very nice to have a symbol like this.

So to me the Cross was His vehicle to save us.

And we think of the Cross as well.

What do we say in the troparia?

"By the power of Thy Cross."

We ask Him to preserve our habitation by the power of the Cross.

The Cross is powerful.

It's not an instrument of death.

It's an instrument of life.

He turned it into an instrument of life.

He turned it around.

10:00

Fr. Seraphim: And the Protestants don't really always have that idea. In fact, I've never heard it. When I was Protestant it was like Christ was killed on the Cross because of the necessity of God's justice having satisfaction.

And the idea that, you know, those of us who are parents — or even if you have a cousin or anybody — they do something bad, and even if you're angry at them, would you require them to do something in order for you to no longer be upset with them?

Would you literally do that?

I mean, can you imagine?

You can't do that.

That's crazy.

I mean, we're human beings.

So we might get mad at our kids or something.

But do they ever stop being our child?

Do we ever stop thinking of them in the light of loving them as our child?

Never.

But the PSA basically has God the Father being separated from us because of that gulf of sin.

God doesn't care about that.

God can do anything He wants.

Protestants believe that.

Bishop Emilianos:

Yes. Not all Protestants, but mostly.

And Roman Catholics believe that too.

Fr. Seraphim: Oh yeah.

Absolutely.

Audience: From my background, I always assumed Jesus died on the Cross because He loved us.

Fr. Seraphim: Yes.

But see, it probably wasn't explained to you much.

Because it's a pretty weird doctrine.

And so often it's just kind of passed over.

And now we have "nice Jesus."

Nice Jesus lets you do anything.

Audience: Yeah, because I've never heard the perspective that He had to die because of God's justice.

Fr. Seraphim: That's much better that you didn't hear that.

Audience: I didn't know Protestants or Roman Catholics believed that.

Fr. Seraphim: We should talk about necessity, Vladika.

Because I know that your elder — he said something that influenced my life greatly.

He said there is no “must.”

We are free.

We can do what we want.

What do I tell you guys when someone says, “Oh, it’s Wednesday, you can’t have ice cream”?

What do I tell you?

Audience: You say we can have ice cream.

Fr. Seraphim: Exactly.

I say, “I can have ice cream. I’m choosing not to.”

We have free will.

We have free will to eat ice cream or not.

We have free will to sin or not.

Jesus Christ had free will.

He had free will to sin or not.

He just chose not to.

Bishop Emilianos: So maybe because that’s the teaching about my elder that influenced my life the most — the idea that there is no must.

But then there is also a must, isn’t there?

Because it’s in your heart.

Your love is in your heart.

And this is exactly what I was saying before.

It is love that drove Christ to be crucified for us.

It was not a must.

It was His love.

And we can see this even in ourselves.

We are created in the image and likeness of God.

So we can see this in ourselves.

When parents sacrifice themselves for their children — Father said that example — but I will give another.

When a child is young and doesn’t allow the parents to sleep during the night, the parents do not think that this is a Cross.

They do it out of love.

They don’t even consider it suffering.

They don’t think about escaping it.

Because they love their children and want to raise them properly.

They will do whatever they can.
But they won't give their child to the neighbor to raise and then take him back later.
They don't do that.
So God loved us in such a way that Christ sacrificed Himself on the Cross for us.
Just for us.
And this is the thing.
The Cross is always connected with sacrifice.
But not because you must.
The martyrs gave their lives out of love for God.
And when you have so much love for God, what you receive in return is love.
There is nothing else to receive.
Because that is the only thing that exists in the end.
And this is the beauty of the Cross.
This sacrifice carries all the grace that we can find.
If we read the lives of the saints, we will understand that their life was a constant Cross.
There is not one saint who did not suffer.
There is not one person who does not suffer.
But the difference is whether we do it for God or not.
If we do it for God, it is considered a Cross.
If we do not do it for God, it is just suffering.
But the Cross carries God.
It carries grace.
It carries eternity.

20:00

Fr. Seraphim: Right. So that's a very important distinction — suffering versus the Cross. Everyone suffers. Everyone has difficulties. Everyone has things that they struggle with. But the question is whether we unite those struggles with Christ.

If we unite them with Christ, then they become the Cross. If we do not unite them with Christ, then they remain simply suffering.

And suffering by itself doesn't save anyone.

But the Cross saves.

And the Cross saves because Christ is in it.

Christ transforms suffering.

He enters into suffering.

And when He enters into suffering, suffering becomes something else.
It becomes a path to life.

Bishop Emilianos:Yes.

And when we speak about the Cross we must always remember that the Cross cannot be separated from the Resurrection.

If we remove the Resurrection, the Cross would simply be a tragedy.

It would simply be a a terrible death.

But the Cross together with the Resurrection becomes victory.

Christ enters death and destroys death from within.

And this is something very important.

God does not destroy death from outside.

He destroys death by entering it.

He accepts death voluntarily.

And by accepting death He destroys the power of death.

Fr. Seraphim:Right.

And that's why in the services we say that Christ trampled down death by death.

He destroyed death by entering into it.

And so the Cross is not defeat.

The Cross is victory.

But it is a victory that looks like defeat.

And that's part of the mystery.

Because God does things in a way that the world does not expect.

The world expects power.

The world expects domination.

The world expects victory through force.

But God conquers through humility.

He conquers through love.

He conquers through sacrifice.

Bishop Emilianos:Yes.

And this is why the Cross is difficult for many people to understand.

Because the Cross does not follow the logic of the world.

The logic of the world is power.

But the logic of God is love.

And love always involves sacrifice.

When you truly love someone, you are willing to sacrifice yourself for that person.

This is true in families.

This is true in friendships.

This is true in every form of real love.

And this is why the Cross reveals the love of God.

Christ sacrifices Himself for us.

And in doing so He reveals what divine love truly is.

Fr. Seraphim: And this is something that we have to learn slowly.

Because we tend to think in worldly categories.

We think about success.

We think about power.

We think about recognition.

But the Gospel teaches something very different.

The Gospel teaches humility.

The Gospel teaches repentance.

The Gospel teaches sacrifice.

And all of those things are connected with the Cross.

Audience: So when Christ says that we must take up our Cross, what exactly does that mean?

Fr. Seraphim: It means that we must follow Him in the way of love and sacrifice.

It doesn't mean that we go looking for suffering.

Some people misunderstand that.

They think that holiness means seeking suffering.

But that's not true.

We don't look for suffering.

But when suffering comes, we unite it with Christ.

And when we unite it with Christ, it becomes salvific.

30:00

Bishop Emilianos: Yes. And this is something that we see in the lives of the saints.

The saints did not go looking for suffering. They went looking for God.

But when suffering came, they accepted it with love.

And because they accepted it with love, their suffering became a Cross.

And the Cross always brings grace.

Fr. Seraphim: Right. And that's why when we speak about the Cross we should never speak about it in a negative way.

The Cross is not something dark.

The Cross is light.

The Cross is joy.

It doesn't look like joy at first.

But in the end it brings joy.

Bishop Emilianos:Yes. And this is something that we must remember.

Christ did not go to the Cross because He was forced.

He went to the Cross because He loved us.

And this is why the Cross reveals the love of God more than anything else.

Fr. Seraphim:And that's why the Cross is everywhere in the Church.

We make the sign of the Cross.

We venerate the Cross.

We wear the Cross.

The Cross is always before our eyes.

Because the Cross reminds us of the love of Christ.

And it also reminds us of how we must live.

Audience:So the Cross becomes the pattern for the Christian life?

Fr. Seraphim:Exactly.

Christ says very clearly, "If anyone would come after Me, let him deny himself, take up his Cross, and follow Me."

So the Cross becomes the pattern for how we live.

We deny ourselves.

We love others.

We sacrifice for others.

And in doing that we become like Christ.

Bishop Emilianos:Yes. And this is the meaning of the Christian life.

The Christian life is the life of love.

And love always involves sacrifice.

But when sacrifice is done in love, it becomes joy.

It becomes grace.

It becomes life.

Fr. Seraphim:And that's why the Cross is not something that we should fear.

It is something that we should embrace.

Because through the Cross we find Christ.

And through Christ we find life.

40:00

Audience: I know we're supposed to carry our Cross in love with Christ, but I've been in a very dark place. And I'm finding that I cannot resist sin anymore. I don't feel like I can grow in my faith, and it just feels pointless. Because if the purpose is to become like God — and I can't do that — then what's the point of living?

And I guess my question is: do I love God enough? And if I don't love God enough, what's the point?

Fr. Seraphim: Well, first of all, you're equating love for God with asceticism. Those are not the same thing.

You can be very ascetic and not love God very much. And you can have very little asceticism and love God deeply.

Love God according to your abilities.

I constantly tell people: read the Gospels. Read the Gospels over and over again. And read the Psalter.

The Gospels and the Psalter together will teach you how to experience God.

Right now you know things about God, but you haven't experienced Him very deeply.

When you experience God, then you will understand something very important.

You will realize that you are a sinner, but you will also know that God loves you.

And that knowledge changes everything.

Bishop Emilianos: Yes. And I think you are putting too many "musts" on yourself.

You say, "I must do this, I must do that."

But there should not be so many musts.

Do what you can according to your strength.

That is enough.

Even Saint Paisios once had a temptation. He wondered if Christ was truly God.

And he said to himself something very interesting.

He said, "Even if Christ were only a very holy man, I would still love Him. Because He is good. Because He is beautiful."

So free yourself from the pressure that you must become extremely ascetic.

Follow your conscience.

Do what you can.

God will do the rest.

Audience: But it still feels like I keep failing.

Fr. Seraphim: Everyone fails.

That's normal.

That's part of the Christian life.

You fall.

You get up.

You fall again.

You get up again.

The problem is not falling.

The problem is despair.

Despair is the devil's favorite weapon.

Because once you despair, he can manipulate you easily.

Bishop Emilianos: Yes. Despair is one of the greatest dangers in the spiritual life.

When someone despairs, they believe that God has abandoned them.

But that is never true.

God never abandons us.

The devil tries to convince us of that.

But it is a lie.

Audience: Is that connected with the Prayer of Saint Ephrem, when it talks about the spirit of despair?

Bishop Emilianos: Yes.

The Greek word that is used there can also mean something like distraction or curiosity — the kind of curiosity that fills the mind with useless thoughts.

When the mind becomes distracted like that, it cannot receive good things.

And eventually that leads to despair.

Because the mind becomes dark.

And the devil works very strongly in that darkness.

50:00

Bishop Emilianos: There is also something else that one of the elders used to say. He said that not being joyful is a blasphemy against the Holy Spirit.

Now when people hear that, they are shocked. But what he meant is this: if we truly understand the love of God, if we truly understand what Christ has done for us, then we should not allow ourselves to fall into despair.

Because Christ has already defeated death. He has already destroyed sin.

So our sadness cannot be absolute.

Even when we suffer, there is hope.

Even when we struggle, there is hope.

And that hope is Christ.

Fr. Seraphim:Right.

And I think another thing that's important is that we misunderstand what forgiveness is.

In Protestant thinking, forgiveness is usually understood as avoiding punishment. You are forgiven so that you will not be punished and can go to heaven.

But that is not how the Orthodox Church understands forgiveness.

Forgiveness is about healing.

We are being healed so that the Kingdom of Heaven can be within us.

Christ said, "The Kingdom of God is within you."

So salvation is not simply about going somewhere after death.

It is about becoming something.

It is about becoming like Christ.

Audience:So it's not just about having our sins erased?

Fr. Seraphim:Exactly.

It is not simply erasing a record.

It is transformation.

And the Cross is the beginning of that transformation.

Christ took our human nature and united it to Himself.

He entered death.

He destroyed death.

And then He raised human nature up with Him.

That is why the Resurrection is so important.

Without the Resurrection, the Cross would just be a tragedy.

But because of the Resurrection, the Cross becomes victory.

Bishop Emilianos:Yes.

The Cross and the Resurrection cannot be separated.

They are one mystery.

Christ dies on the Cross out of love.

And through that love He destroys death.

This is why the Cross is always connected with joy in the Church.

When we venerate the Cross, we do not do it with despair.

We do it with hope.

Because the Cross is the sign of victory.

60:00

Fr. Seraphim: Another thing about the Cross is that it is the pattern for our own life.

Christ says very clearly, "If anyone would come after Me, let him deny himself, take up his Cross, and follow Me."

So the Cross is not just something that Christ did.

It is something that we must participate in.

But again, this is not because we are forced.

It is because of love.

If we love Christ, we will naturally want to follow Him.

And following Him means taking up our Cross.

Audience: What does it mean practically to take up our Cross?

Fr. Seraphim: It means accepting the difficulties that come into our life and offering them to God.

Everyone has difficulties.

Everyone suffers.

The question is whether we unite that suffering to Christ or not.

If we unite it to Christ, it becomes a Cross.

If we do not unite it to Christ, then it is just meaningless suffering.

Bishop Emilianos: Yes.

And when we unite our suffering with Christ, something changes.

Grace enters.

The suffering does not necessarily disappear.

But it becomes different.

It becomes meaningful.

It becomes part of our salvation.

Audience: So suffering itself is not the goal?

Bishop Emilianos: No.

Suffering is not the goal.

Love is the goal.

But love often requires sacrifice.

And sacrifice often includes suffering.

But the suffering is not the point.

The love is the point.

Fr. Seraphim: Right.

That's why we should never seek suffering.

Some people think holiness means looking for suffering.

That is not true.
We should seek God.
And if suffering comes, we accept it.
But we do not go looking for it.

70:00

Bishop Emilianos: And when we understand this, we begin to understand why the Cross is central to the Christian life.

Because the Cross teaches us how to love.
The Holy Trinity itself is love.
Each Person of the Holy Trinity gives Himself completely to the others.
This is eternal love.
When we begin to live according to the Cross, we begin to participate in that love.

Fr. Seraphim: Yes.

And that is why the commandments are not arbitrary rules.
They are instructions for becoming like Christ.
When Christ tells us to forgive, He is teaching us to become like Him.
When He tells us to love our enemies, He is teaching us to become like Him.
The commandments are the path to becoming what we were created to be.

Audience: But that still seems very difficult.

Fr. Seraphim: Of course it is difficult.

But it becomes easier when we understand that God helps us.
We are not doing this alone.
Grace is working in us.
And that grace comes to us through the life of the Church.
Through prayer.
Through the sacraments.
Through repentance.
All of these things help us to grow.

Bishop Emilianos: Yes.

And we should also remember that spiritual growth takes time.
It is not something that happens instantly.
It is a lifelong process.
But if we remain faithful, God will complete the work that He has begun in us.

Fr. Seraphim: And that's why the Cross is so central in the Church.

We make the sign of the Cross all the time.

We venerate the Cross.

We sing about the Cross.

Because the Cross is the sign of Christ's victory.

It is the sign of His love.

And it is also the pattern for our own life.

80:00

Bishop Emilianos: Yes.

The Cross shows us how God loves.

And it also shows us how we must love.

We are called to love in the same way.

Not selfishly.

But sacrificially.

When we begin to love like that, we begin to understand God.

Because God is love.

Fr. Seraphim: And when we understand that, the Cross stops being something frightening.

Instead, it becomes something beautiful.

Because it shows us the depth of God's love for us.

Christ did not go to the Cross because He was forced.

He went to the Cross because He loved us.

And through the Cross He destroyed death.

He opened the gates of Paradise.

And He united humanity with God.

That is why the Cross stands at the center of the Christian faith.

Bishop Emilianos: Yes.

The Cross is love.

The Cross is victory.

The Cross is life.

And when we live according to the Cross, we begin to experience the life of God.

Fr. Seraphim: Glory to Thee, O Christ our God, our hope, glory to Thee.

Amen.

Audience: And I don't see that anywhere else, but I do see that here. And it's very beautiful. That's all.

Fr. Seraphim:All right. So we'll end here and we'll reconvene.

We're going to have Vespers in just a minute and then a full slate of services this week.

You can look on the calendar for that.

And then Bishop Binos and Father Chris will be here next week as well.

Okay.

Audience:Thank you for speaking out for that part of hearing. That was so much easier.

Fr. Seraphim:Well, we'll boost the audio when we do the video too.

Audience:It is truly meet and right...

[singing]

[music]

Audience:Thank you. Thank you, Father.

End of Transcript.